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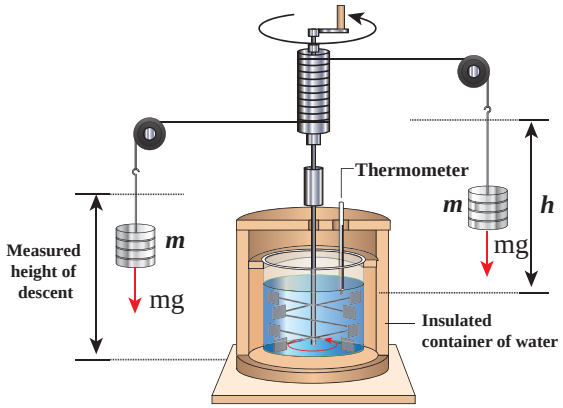


Figure.8.19 Joule's experiment for determining the mechanical equivalent of heat energy.

a rise in temperature of the water. This implies that gravitational potential energy is converted to internal energy of water. The temperature of water increases due to the work done by the masses. In fact, Joule was able to show that the mechanical work has the same effect as giving heat. He found that to raise 1 g of an object by 1°C , 4.186 J of energy is required. In earlier days the heat was measured in calorie.

$$1 \text{ cal} = 4.186 \text{ J}$$

This is called Joule's mechanical equivalent of heat.

Note

Before James Prescott Joule, people thought that heat was a kind of fluid called caloric fluid which flows from an object at high temperature to that in low temperature. According to caloric fluid idea, the hot object contains more caloric fluid and the cold object contains less caloric fluid since heat was treated as a quantity. Now we understand that heat is not a quantity but it is an energy in transit. So the word 'mechanical equivalent of heat' is wrong terminology. Because mechanical energy is a quantity and any object can contain more or less mechanical energy, but this is not so with heat as it is not a quantity. However this terminology is retained for historical reasons. A correct name would be 'Joule's mechanical equivalence of internal energy'. Joule Essentially converted mechanical energy to internal energy. In his experiment potential energy is converted to rotational kinetic energy of paddle wheel and this rotational kinetic energy is converted to internal energy of water.

EXAMPLE 8.11

A student had a breakfast of 200 food calories. He thinks of burning this energy by drawing water from the well and watering the trees in his school. Depth of the well is about 25 m. The pot can hold 25L of water and each tree requires one pot of water. How many trees can he water? (Neglect the mass of the pot and the energy spent by walking. Take g =10 m s^{-2})





Solution

To draw 25 L of water from the well, the student has to do work against gravity by burning his energy.

Mass of the water = 25 L = 25 kg (1L=1kg)

The work required to draw 25 kg of water = gravitational potential energy gained by water.

$W = mgh = 25 \times 10 \times 25 = 6250\ J$